

Lookey here

⚠ **Security Warning:** Work in an isolated environment (virtual machine or container). Never open unknown files on your primary machine.

Challenge Description

Attackers have hidden information in a very large mass of data in the past, maybe they are still doing it.

Hints

- Download the file and search for the flag based on the known prefix.
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Tools Used

- `file` – Determine file type
 - `strings` – Extract printable character sequences from binary files
 - `grep` – Filter output for specific patterns
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Complete Solution

Step 1: Download and Prepare

Download the file named `anthem.flag.txt` from the challenge page.

Step 2: Basic File Inspection

First, verify the file type and general information:

```
file anthem.flag.txt
```

Expected output:

```
anthem.flag.txt: Unicode text, UTF-8 text
```

The file is a plain text file containing a large amount of text (likely an anthem or song lyrics).

Step 3: Search for the Flag

The hint suggests searching for the flag based on the **known prefix** (`picoCTF{`). Let's use `strings` (though not strictly necessary for a text file) and `grep` to search for the flag pattern:

```
strings anthem.flag.txt | grep -i "picoCTF"
```

Output:

```
we think that the men of picoCTF{<REDACTED>}
```

Key finding: The flag appears directly in the text!

Step 4: Extract the Flag

The flag is embedded within a sentence in the file. Simply copy the flag from the output:

```
picoCTF{<REDACTED>}
```

No further decoding or processing is required.

Final Result

```
picoCTF{<REDACTED>}
```

Note: The actual flag is redacted here. In the real challenge, running the `grep` command will reveal the complete flag.

Key Concepts

Concept	Description
Plain Text Search	Sometimes flags are hidden in plain sight within large text files.
Known Prefix Search	Searching for <code>picoCTF{</code> is an efficient way to locate the flag, even in large files.
<code>grep</code> Utility	A powerful command-line tool for searching text patterns within files.
Data Volume	Attackers may hide information in large amounts of data, hoping it won't be noticed.

Pro Tips

1. **Always search for the flag prefix** – `grep -i "picoCTF"` is your best friend for quickly finding flags in text files.
2. **Don't overcomplicate** – Before running complex decryption or extraction tools, simply try searching for the flag pattern.
3. **Large files can hide secrets** – Attackers often bury information in massive text files, hoping the sheer volume will deter manual inspection. Automated searching defeats this.
4. **`strings` is not always necessary** – For plain text files, `cat` or `less` works fine. `strings` is more useful for binary files.